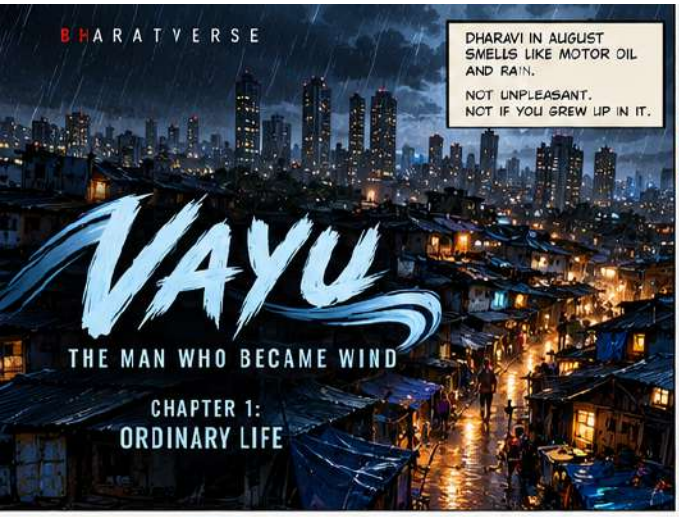
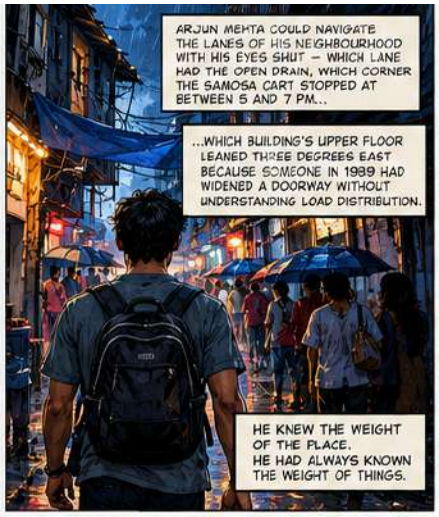
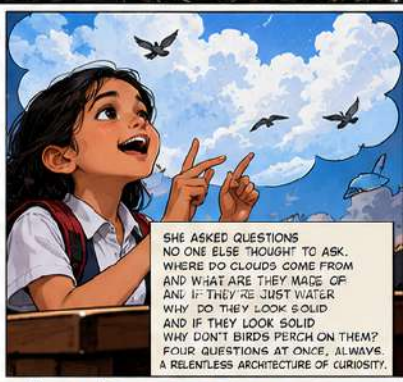

BHARATVERSE
DHARAVI IN AUGUST SMELLS LIKE MOTOR OIL AND RAIN.
NOT UNPLEASANT. NOT IF YOU GREW UP IN IT.
VAYU
THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND
CHAPTER 1: ORDINARY LIFE


ARJUN MEHTA COULD NAVIGATE THE LANES OF HIS NEIGHBOURHOOD WITH HIS EYES SHUT — WHICH LANE HAD THE OPEN DRAIN, WHICH CORNER THE SAMOSA CART STOPPED AT BETWEEN 5 AND 7 PM...
...WHICH BUILDING'S UPPER FLOOR LEANED THREE DEGREES EAST BECAUSE SOMEONE IN 1989 HAD WIDENED A DOORWAY WITHOUT UNDERSTANDING LOAD DISTRIBUTION.
HE KNEW THE WEIGHT OF THE PLACE. HE HAD ALWAYS KNOWN THE WEIGHT OF THINGS.

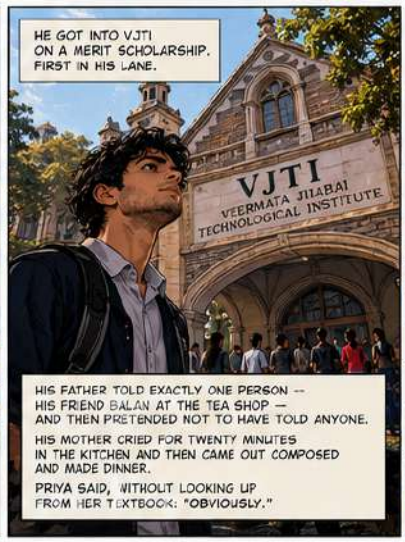

HIS FATHER, SURESH, FIXED MOTORCYCLES IN A TWO-BAY GARAGE ON THEIR LANE.
SURESH WAS NOT A BRILLIANT MAN BUT HE WAS A PRECISE ONE — HE COULD HEAR A MISFIRE IN AN ENGINE THE WAY OTHER MEN HEARD A WRONG NOTE IN A SONG.
ARJUN HAD INHERITED THIS. NOT THE MOTORCYCLES. THE LISTENING.


HIS MOTHER, LATA, TAUGHT CLASS 7 MATHEMATICS AT THE MUNICIPAL SCHOOL THREE LANES OVER.
"A BUILDING DOES NOT COLLAPSE WITHOUT WARNING. IT ALWAYS TELLS YOU. YOU JUST HAVE TO KNOW WHAT TO LISTEN FOR."
SHE BELIEVED — DEEPLY, QUIETLY, WITHOUT ANNOUNCEMENT — THAT THE ABILITY TO UNDERSTAND A PATTERN WAS THE MOST IMPORTANT THING A PERSON COULD POSSESS.
HE HEARD THIS FIRST AT EIGHT YEARS OLD. HE DID NOT UNDERSTAND IT THEN. HE WOULD, EVENTUALLY, UNDERSTAND IT TOO WELL.


HIS SISTER PRIYA ARRIVED FOUR YEARS AFTER HIM AND IMMEDIATELY BECAME THE SUN AROUND WHICH THE REST OF THE FAMILY ORBITED.
NOT BECAUSE SHE DEMANDED IT. BECAUSE SHE GENERATED IT — WARMTH, LIGHT, FORCE OF WILL IN A FIVE-YEAR-OLD'S BODY THAT MADE ADULTS STOP AND LOOK TWICE.


SHE ASKED QUESTIONS NO ONE ELSE THOUGHT TO ASK. WHERE DO CLOUDS COME FROM AND WHAT ARE THEY MADE OF AND IF THEY'RE JUST WATER WHY DO THEY LOOK SOLID AND IF THEY LOOK SOLID WHY DON'T BIRDS PERCH ON THEM? FOUR QUESTIONS AT ONCE, ALWAYS. A RELENTLESS ARCHITECTURE OF CURIOSITY.


ARJUN ADORED HER. HE WOULD NEVER SAY THIS DIRECTLY. HE SHOWED IT BY CHECKING HER MATHS HOMEWORK EVEN WHEN SHE DIDN'T ASK, BY WALKING HER TO SCHOOL ON MORNINGS WHEN THE DRUNK MAN WAS USUALLY AT THE CORNER, BY LETTING HER PICK THE ONE TV CHANNEL THEY WERE ALLOWED ON WEEKNIGHTS.
SHE KNEW. SHE NEVER SAID IT EITHER. THEY WERE A FAMILY THAT DEMONSTRATED THINGS.


HE GOT INTO VJTI ON A MERIT SCHOLARSHIP. FIRST IN HIS LANE.
VJTI
VEERMATA JIJABAI TECHNOLOGICAL INSTITUTE
HIS FATHER TOLD EXACTLY ONE PERSON -- HIS FRIEND BALAN AT THE TEA SHOP — AND THEN PRETENDED NOT TO HAVE TOLD ANYONE.
HIS MOTHER CRIED FOR TWENTY MINUTES IN THE KITCHEN AND THEN CAME OUT COMPOSED AND MADE DINNER.
PRIYA SAID, WITHOUT LOOKING UP FROM HER TEXTBOOK: "OBVIOUSLY."


HE NEARLY LOST THE SCHOLARSHIP TWICE.
ONCE IN SECOND YEAR WHEN HE FAILED A THERMODYNAMICS EXAM HE HAD BEEN TOO EXHAUSTED TO STUDY FOR — NIGHT SHIFT AT A CALL CENTRE TO COVER THE GAP HIS SCHOLARSHIP DIDN'T.
ONCE IN FOURTH YEAR WHEN HIS PROJECT PARTNER VANISHED THREE DAYS BEFORE SUBMISSION AND ARJUN HAD TO REBUILD THE STRUCTURAL LOAD ANALYSIS FROM SCRATCH IN SEVENTY-TWO HOURS.
HE DID BOTH TIMES WHAT HE ALWAYS DID: CALCULATED WHAT WAS REQUIRED, APPLIED HIMSELF, DID NOT COMPLAIN ABOUT IT.


MANTRI
INFRASTRUCTURE CONSULTANTS
HE GRADUATED. HE GOT A JOB AT MANTRI INFRASTRUCTURE CONSULTANTS.
HE WAS GOOD AT IT. HE NEVER TALKED ABOUT BEING GOOD AT IT.
HE SENT MONEY HOME ON THE FIRST OF EVERY MONTH. HE CALLED HIS MOTHER EVERY SUNDAY AT 10 AM.
HE HAD NO DESTINY. HE HAD A ROUTINE. AND FOR A WHILE — FOR FOUR SOLID, UNREMARKABLE YEARS — THAT WAS ENOUGH.

BHARATVERSE

VAYU

THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND

CHAPTER 2 :
AHERI

THE FACILITY WAS SET INTO THE RED ROCK OF THE DECCAN PLATEAU LIKE A WOUND. CONCRETE AND STEEL OVER SOMETHING ANCIENT.

MUMBAI. SUNDAY DINNER.

THAT'S DR. KIRAN RAO'S PROJECT.

YOU KNOW IT?

I'VE READ EVERYTHING SHE'S PUBLISHED. SHE'S TRYING TO TAP PRESSURE DIFFERENTIAL BETWEEN THE STRATOSPHERE AND SURFACE LAYER AS A CLEAN ENERGY SOURCE.

IT'S EITHER THIRTY YEARS AHEAD OF ITS TIME OR COMPLETELY WRONG. NO ONE'S SURE WHICH.

MY FIRM HAS BEEN CONTRACTED FOR A STRUCTURAL ASSESSMENT OF THE CONTAINMENT CHAMBER AT THE FACILITY OUTSIDE NAGPUR.

TWO DAYS OF SITE VISITS, MEASUREMENTS, STRESS CALCULATIONS, A REPORT. ROUTINE.

I HAVE MY ID FROM ICT. YOU CAN PUT ME DOWN AS A JUNIOR CONSULTANT.

PLEASE, ARJUN. THIS IS INCREDIBLE. I'VE ALWAYS WANTED TO SEE HER WORK FIRSTHAND.

HE SHOULD NOT HAVE DONE THIS. HE KNEW LATER THAT HE SHOULD NOT HAVE DONE THIS. AT THE TIME IT SEEMED LIKE A SMALL KINDNESS FOR A SISTER WHO LIT UP WHEN SHE TALKED ABOUT PRESSURE DIFFERENTIALS.

THE JOURNEY TO AHERI.

NAGPUR 312 km

AHERI 48 km

ARJUN NOTICED, AS HE ALWAYS NOTICED, THAT THE GROUND HAD A PARTICULAR QUALITY HERE — A DENSITY, A PRESENCE. HE COULD NOT EXPLAIN THIS. HE FILED IT AWAY.

DR. KIRAN RAO MET THEM IN THE MAIN CORRIDOR.

SHE WAS FIFTY-THREE, SMALL, PRECISE IN HER MOVEMENTS, WITH EYES THAT DID NOT REST ON ANYTHING FOR LONG.

SHE IMMEDIATELY BEGAN TALKING TO PRIYA ABOUT STRATOSPHERIC COUPLING WHILE ARJUN WALKED THE CHAMBER PERIMETER AND TOOK MEASUREMENTS.

THE CONTAINMENT CHAMBER.

IMMENSE. ENGINEERED FOR PRESSURE, BUILT FOR AN EXPERIMENT THAT COULD CHANGE HOW THE WORLD LOOKS AT ENERGY.

HE FOUND THE FAULT ON HIS SECOND PASS.

SECTION 7-C OF THE INNER CONTAINMENT WALL — A MICRO-FRACTURE CLUSTER, PROBABLY FROM THE EXCAVATION BLASTING EIGHTEEN MONTHS EARLIER, PROPAGATED SLIGHTLY FURTHER THAN THE INITIAL INSPECTION HAD CAUGHT.

7-C

STRESS CATEGORY THREE. NON-CRITICAL AT CURRENT OPERATIONAL LOADS.
A CONCERN IF THE EXPERIMENT RAN ABOVE 110% OF DESIGN CAPACITY.

HE FLAGGED IT IN HIS REPORT. HE HIGHLIGHTED IT. HE ATTACHED A SUPPLEMENTAL NOTE THAT SAID, IN PLAIN LANGUAGE:

STRUCTURAL ASSESSMENT REPORT
AHERI FACILITY

7-C

Do not run this system above design capacity until 7-C is assessed and if necessary reinforced. The risk is structural failure of the containment wall.

DR. KIRAN RAO'S PROJECT REVIEW WAS IN SIX WEEKS.

HER FUNDING WAS ALREADY ON THIN ICE — A BUREAUCRATIC DISPUTE OVER TIMELINES AND DELIVERABLES THAT HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH THE SCIENCE.

SHE NEEDED RESULTS BEFORE THAT REVIEW. SHE HAD ALREADY PUSHED THE TEST TIMELINE UP BY THREE MONTHS.

SHE SIGNED OVER HIS SUPPLEMENTAL NOTE.

NOT MISSING IT — IT WAS HIGHLIGHTED.
SHE SIGNED OVER IT ANYWAY.

HE DID NOT KNOW THIS UNTIL MUCH LATER. ON THE DAY HE LEFT THE FACILITY, ARJUN FILED HIS REPORT, SHOOK HANDS WITH THE PROJECT COORDINATOR, AND DROVE BACK TO MUMBAI.

AHERI
ATMOSPHERIC RESEARCH FACILITY

HE CALLED HIS MOTHER ON SUNDAY.

HE WENT TO WORK ON MONDAY.

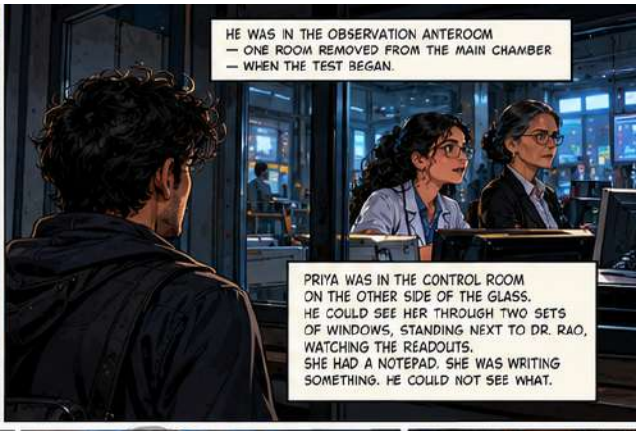
THE EXPERIMENT WAS SCHEDULED FOR A TUESDAY. 4 AM, WHEN THE ATMOSPHERIC DIFFERENTIAL WOULD BE AT ITS PEAK.

PRIYA HAD BEEN INVITED TO OBSERVE.

SHE SAID YES BEFORE DR. RAO FINISHED THE SENTENCE.


BHARATVERSE
VAYU
THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND
CHAPTER 3:
4:17 AM
HE WAS NOT SUPPOSED TO BE THERE.

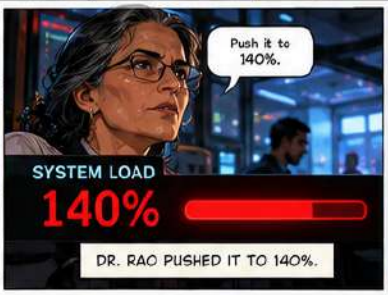

HE HAD DRIVEN BACK TO NAGPUR THE NIGHT BEFORE BECAUSE PRIYA HAD CALLED, EXCITED IN A WAY THAT WAS CONTAGIOUS EVEN THROUGH A BAD MOBILE CONNECTION.
HE PARKED TWO HUNDRED METRES FROM THE FACILITY AT 3:45 AM.
IT WAS A CLEAR NIGHT. THE DECCAN SKY AT THIS HOUR WAS EXTRAORDINARY — NO LIGHT POLLUTION, THE MILKY WAY A SMEAR OF WHITE ACROSS BLACK. HE STOOD OUTSIDE HIS CAR FOR A MOMENT LOOKING UP, WHICH WAS NOT SOMETHING HE NORMALLY DID.
LATER HE WOULD THINK ABOUT THAT. WHY HE STOPPED TO LOOK AT THE SKY.

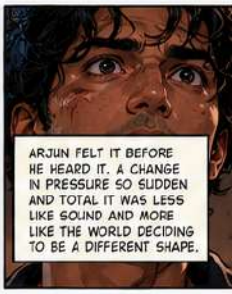

HE WAS IN THE OBSERVATION ANTEROOM — ONE ROOM REMOVED FROM THE MAIN CHAMBER — WHEN THE TEST BEGAN.
PRIYA WAS IN THE CONTROL ROOM ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE GLASS. HE COULD SEE HER THROUGH TWO SETS OF WINDOWS, STANDING NEXT TO DR. RAO, WATCHING THE READOUTS. SHE HAD A NOTEPAD. SHE WAS WRITING SOMETHING. HE COULD NOT SEE WHAT.


We're at 100%. Readings are stable!
Good. Hold it. Let it stabilize.
SYSTEM LOAD
100%
THE RIG CAME UP TO 100%.

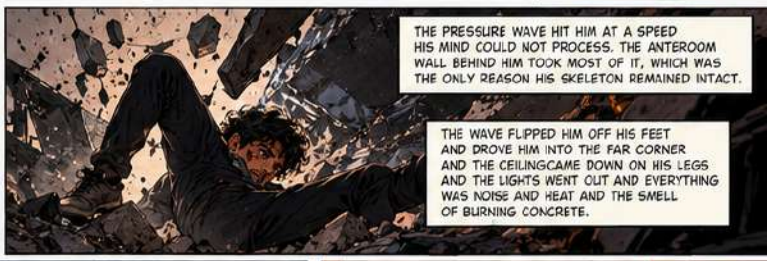

Still holding! This is good!
Increase to 110%.
SYSTEM LOAD
110%
THEN 110%. THE READING HELD. NUMBERS WERE GOOD.


This is incredible. We might actually —
SOMEONE IN THE CONTROL ROOM STARTED TO SAY SOMETHING THAT MIGHT HAVE BEEN CONGRATULATIONS.

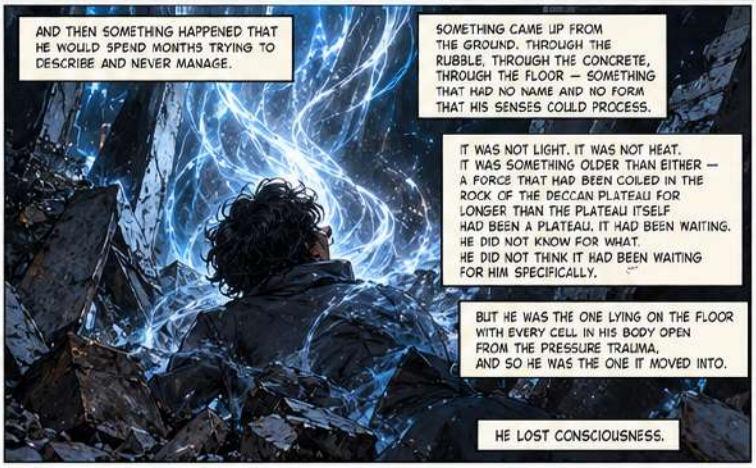

Push it to 140%.
SYSTEM LOAD
140%
DR. RAO PUSHED IT TO 140%.


ARJUN FELT IT BEFORE HE HEARD IT. A CHANGE IN PRESSURE SO SUDDEN AND TOTAL IT WAS LESS LIKE SOUND AND MORE LIKE THE WORLD DECIDING TO BE A DIFFERENT SHAPE.


THEN THE WALL OF THE CONTAINMENT CHAMBER — SECTION 7-C — OPENED LIKE A MOUTH.
7-C


THE PRESSURE WAVE HIT HIM AT A SPEED HIS MIND COULD NOT PROCESS. THE ANTEROOM WALL BEHIND HIM TOOK MOST OF IT, WHICH WAS THE ONLY REASON HIS SKELETON REMAINED INTACT.
THE WAVE FLIPPED HIM OFF HIS FEET AND DROVE HIM INTO THE FAR CORNER AND THE CEILINGCAME DOWN ON HIS LEGS AND THE LIGHTS WENT OUT AND EVERYTHING WAS NOISE AND HEAT AND THE SMELL OF BURNING CONCRETE.


HE COULD NOT BREATHE. NOT FROM INJURY — THE PRESSURE HAD SIMPLY REMOVED ALL THE AIR FROM THE ROOM.
THE AIR RETURNED, RUSHING BACK IN A VIOLENT REVERSE-WAVE, AND THEN HE COULD BREATHE AND HE WAS TRYING TO CALL PRIYA'S NAME AND NOTHING WAS COMING OUT.


AND THEN SOMETHING HAPPENED THAT HE WOULD SPEND MONTHS TRYING TO DESCRIBE AND NEVER MANAGE.
SOMETHING CAME UP FROM THE GROUND. THROUGH THE RUBBLE, THROUGH THE CONCRETE, THROUGH THE FLOOR — SOMETHING THAT HAD NO NAME AND NO FORM THAT HIS SENSES COULD PROCESS.
IT WAS NOT LIGHT. IT WAS NOT HEAT. IT WAS SOMETHING OLDER THAN EITHER — A FORCE THAT HAD BEEN COILED IN THE ROCK OF THE DECCAN PLATEAU FOR LONGER THAN THE PLATEAU ITSELF HAD BEEN A PLATEAU. IT HAD BEEN WAITING. HE DID NOT KNOW FOR WHAT. HE DID NOT THINK IT HAD BEEN WAITING FOR HIM SPECIFICALLY.
BUT HE WAS THE ONE LYING ON THE FLOOR WITH EVERY CELL IN HIS BODY OPEN FROM THE PRESSURE TRAUMA, AND SO HE WAS THE ONE IT MOVED INTO.
HE LOST CONSCIOUSNESS.


WHEN THE RESCUE TEAMS REACHED THE FACILITY THREE HOURS LATER, THEY FOUND TWELVE DEAD. THREE SURVIVORS WITH CRITICAL INJURIES.
AND ARJUN MEHTA, WHO HAD NO INJURIES AT ALL, UNCONSCIOUS IN THE RUBBLE WITH A PULSE OF 44 AND BLOOD PRESSURE READINGS THAT KEPT ERRORING OUT THE INSTRUMENTS.
PRIYA WAS NOT FOUND. NO BODY, NO TRACE. NO BLOOD. NO EQUIPMENT SHE HAD BEEN HOLDING. AS IF SHE HAD BEEN REMOVED FROM THE ROOM RATHER THAN DESTROYED BY IT.
THE OFFICIAL REPORT WOULD SAY: ONE PERSON UNACCOUNTED FOR, PRESUMED DEAD.
ARJUN WOULD NEVER BELIEVE THIS. NOT FOR A SINGLE DAY.

BHARATVERSE

VAYU

THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND

CHAPTER 4: STILLNESS

SAME CITY.
A DIFFERENT ARJUN.

HE CHECKED HIMSELF OUT OF THE NAGPUR HOSPITAL IN THIRTY-SIX HOURS. THE DOCTORS DID NOT WANT HIM TO GO.

EVERY TEST THEY RAN CAME BACK CLEAN. SOMETIMES IMPOSSIBLY CLEAN. HIS ABNORMAL BLOOD PRESSURE READINGS WERE SOMETHING THEIR EQUIPMENT MIGHT HAVE CAUSED ITSELF. SO THEY SIGNED THE DISCHARGE AND WATCHED HIM LEAVE.

WITH THE EXPRESSION OF PEOPLE WHO HAD ENCOUNTERED SOMETHING THEY WOULD BE PUZZLING OVER FOR YEARS.

HE DROVE BACK TO MUMBAI. HE DID NOT CALL HIS MOTHER UNTIL HE WAS IN HIS OWN FLAT, BECAUSE HE NEEDED TO BE SOMEWHERE THAT WAS HIS OWN BEFORE HE SAID THE WORDS OUT LOUD.

Priya... Missing. Probably.

HIS MOTHER WENT SILENT FOR A LONG TIME AND THEN SHE SAID, IN A VOICE SO CONTROLLED IT HURT HIM.

Come home.

HE DID NOT GO HOME.
HE COULD NOT GO HOME YET.

DAY THREE.

HE WAS MAKING TEA AND HIS ANGER — AT DR. RAO, AT THE FACILITY, AT HIMSELF FOR TAKING PRIYA THERE — SPIKED WITHOUT WARNING.

THE WINDOWS IN HIS FLAT OPENED. ALL OF THEM. SIMULTANEOUSLY.

A PRESSURE CHANGE SO FAST THE TEA SPLASHED OUT OF THE MUG AND HIS NEIGHBOUR'S LAUNDRY TORE FROM THE LINE OUTSIDE.

THREE BUILDINGS OVER AN UNSECURED AWNING INVERTED ITSELF AND STAYED

HE STOOD IN HIS KITCHEN FOR A VERY LONG TIME WITHOUT MOVING.

He thought:
THIS IS A STRUCTURAL PROBLEM.
AND STRUCTURAL PROBLEMS HAVE SOLUTIONS.
YOU MEASURE THE LOAD.
YOU IDENTIFY THE FAILURE POINT.
YOU REINFORCE WHAT'S WEAK
AND DISTRIBUTE WHAT'S HEAVY.
YOU DO NOT PANIC.
PANIC IS ENTROPY.
PANIC IS WHAT HAPPENS
WHEN YOU STOP CALCULATING.

HE STARTED CALCULATING.

THE NEXT TWO WEEKS.

HE SPENT TWO WEEKS NOT LEAVING THE FLAT EXCEPT AT 3 AM, WHEN THE STREETS WERE EMPTY.

HE TESTED WHAT HE COULD DO — CAREFULLY, INCREMENTALLY, THE WAY YOU TEST A LOAD-BEARING JOINT.
HOW MUCH FORCE?
IN WHAT DIRECTION?
WHAT'S THE RANGE?
WHAT'S THE COST?

DAY FIVE.

HE DISCOVERED THE PRESSURE SENSE. STANDING ON THE MARINE DRIVE PROMENADE, HE FELT — WITHOUT SEEING — A CAR COMING AROUND THE CORNER BEHIND HIM, FELT THE PRECISE SHAPE OF ITS APPROACH IN THE WAY AIR MOVED AROUND IT.

HE FELT A LOOSE BRACKET ON A STREET LAMP OVERHEAD, THE EXACT POINT WHERE THE METAL HAD BEGUN TO FATIGUE.

HE FELT, DISTANTLY, THE WEIGHT OF THE BUILDINGS ALONG THE WATERFRONT PRESSING DOWN INTO THEIR FOUNDATIONS.

IT WAS NOT UNPLEASANT.
IT WAS ENORMOUS, AND STRANGE, AND NOT UNPLEASANT.

DAY ELEVEN.

HE WENT FASTER THAN HE HAD INTENDED AND FOUND HIMSELF ABOVE THE CITY.

NOT HIGH — MAYBE FORTY METRES — HOVERING IN A WAY THAT SHOULD HAVE BEEN TERRIFYING AND WAS INSTEAD MERELY ASTONISHING.

THE CITY AT NIGHT FROM FORTY METRES. THE LIGHTS OF DHARAVI. HE COULD FEEL THE LANES BELOW LIKE A MAP IN THE AIR.

HE DESCENDED SLOWLY AND DID NOT DO IT AGAIN FOR ANOTHER WEEK, NOT UNTIL HE WAS MORE CERTAIN OF THE MECHANISM.

BACK TO WORK.

MANTRI INFRASTRUCTURE CONSULTANTS

HE WENT BACK TO WORK. HE FILED STRUCTURAL ASSESSMENTS. HE ANSWERED EMAILS. ON THE OUTSIDE HE WAS COMPLETELY UNREMARKABLE.

INSIDE HE WAS AN ONGOING NEGOTIATION BETWEEN THE PERSON HE HAD BEEN AND WHATEVER HE WAS BECOMING.

HE LOOKED FOR PRIYA EVERY DAY.

HOSPITAL DATABASES. MISSING PERSONS RECORDS. TRAFFIC CAMERA ARCHIVES. HE HAD NO REAL LEADS. HE DID NOT STOP LOOKING.

HE TOLD NO ONE.

NOT HIS PARENTS. NOT HIS COLLEAGUES. NOT THE GOVERNMENT.

HE ALREADY KNEW, DIMLY, THAT THE GOVERNMENT WAS LOOKING FOR HIM.

BHARATVERSE

VAYU

THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND

CHAPTER 5:
RAKSHA

THE RAKSHA DIVISION DID NOT OFFICIALLY EXIST. IT EXISTED IN THE WAY MANY INCONVENIENT NECESSITIES EXIST IN INDIAN BUREAUCRACY.

IT WAS FOLDED INTO THE BUDGET OF A DEPARTMENT THAT DID SOMETHING ELSE, STAFFED BY PEOPLE WITH OTHER OFFICIAL TITLES, ANSWERABLE TO A JOINT SECRETARY WHOSE PORTFOLIO WAS LISTED AS "STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENTAL ASSESSMENT".

RAKSHA
STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENTAL ASSESSMENT
ANOMALOUS CAPABILITY EVENTS
WESTERN SECTOR

ITS ACTUAL MANDATE WAS THE IDENTIFICATION, MONITORING, AND CONTAINMENT OF WHAT ITS INTERNAL DOCUMENTS CALLED "ANOMALOUS CAPABILITY EVENTS".

COMMANDER SHALINI BOSE HAD BEEN RUNNING THE DIVISION'S WESTERN SECTOR FOR NINE YEARS. SHE WAS FIFTY-ONE. FORMER IPS, WITH THE BEARING OF SOMEONE WHO HAD LONG SINCE STOPPED BEING SURPRISED BY THINGS AND HAD MOVED ON TO SIMPLY MANAGING THEM.

SHE HAD A FILE ON THE AHERI INCIDENT WITHIN FOUR HOURS OF IT HAPPENING.
SHE HAD A FLAG ON ARJUN MEHTA WITHIN FORTY-EIGHT HOURS.

SUBJECT: ARJUN MEHTA
Incident: Aheri (Classified)
Status: Watch
Capability: Probable
Risk: Low (Current)
Recommendation: Observation Only

THE DID NOT MOVE IMMEDIATELY. SHE WATCHED.

SUBJECT: ARJUN MEHTA
LOCATION: MUMBAI
I.D. CONFIRMED

THE ANALYST'S FIRST REPORT READ:
"SUBJECT DEMONSTRATES PROBABLE ATMOSPHERIC MANIPULATION CAPABILITY. EXTENT UNKNOWN. DISPOSITION: NON-THREATENING. APPEARS TO BE MANAGING THE SITUATION HIMSELF. RECOMMEND OBSERVATION ONLY — PREMATURE CONTACT RISKS FLIGHT RESPONSE."

SHE APPROVED THIS.
SHE WAS NOT IN A HURRY.
SHE HAD LEARNED THAT THE ONES WHO RAN WERE USUALLY THE ONES WHO FELT CORNERED.

SHE SENT ONE PERSON TO MAKE CONTACT. NOT AN AGENT — THAT WOULD HAVE BEEN WRONG FOR THIS. SHE SENT DR. AMARA KRISHNAMURTHY, THE DIVISION'S CAPABILITY ASSESSMENT SPECIALIST, WHO HAD A GENUINE COVER AS A TIFR VISITING RESEARCHER AND A GENUINE ABILITY TO HAVE A CONVERSATION WITH A STRUCTURAL ENGINEER WITHOUT IT FEELING LIKE AN INTERVIEW.

DR. AMARA KRISHNAMURTHY
Capability Assessment Specialist
TIFR (Cover)

THEY MET AT A CONFERENCE IN PUNE.

NATIONAL CONFERENCE ON STRUCTURAL ENGINEERING
PUNE

AMARA SPENT TWENTY MINUTES TALKING TO ARJUN ABOUT BRIDGE LOAD DISTRIBUTION BEFORE SHE VERY CAREFULLY LET THE CONVERSATION DRIFT TOWARD AHERI.

The load distribution in cable-stayed bridges is fascinating, isn't it?

Yeah. It's all about how forces move, not just where they are applied.

SHE WAS WATCHING HIS HANDS. PEOPLE WHO COULD MOVE AIR, SHE HAD FOUND, OFTEN REVEALED IT IN THEIR HANDS — A SLIGHT UNCONSCIOUS DISPLACEMENT, A MICROWIND.

HIS HANDS WERE COMPLETELY STILL. HE WAS CONTROLLING IT PERFECTLY.

HE KNEW EXACTLY WHAT SHE WAS. HE WAS NOT SURE HOW HE KNEW — THE PRESSURE SENSE, MAYBE, SOMETHING IN THE WAY SHE HELD HERSELF, SOMETHING TOO DELIBERATE ABOUT THE ENCOUNTER'S APPARENT CASUALNESS.

Tell your organization I'm not interested.

Tell them also that if they follow me into my flat I will know immediately.

AMARA WENT BACK TO SHALINI.

He knows we exist. He's not scared of us. He's not hostile, either. He's — waiting for something.

Waiting for what?

His sister.

SHALINI PULLED THE PRIYA MEHTA FILE. READ IT TWICE.

PRIYA MEHTA

THEN SHE PUT IT IN A DRAWER. BECAUSE THERE WERE THINGS IN THAT FILE THAT SHE WAS NOT YET SURE WHAT TO DO WITH — THINGS THAT SUGGESTED THE AHERI INCIDENT HAD BEEN CONSIDERABLY MORE COMPLEX THAN A CONTAINMENT FAILURE, AND THAT THE PEOPLE WHO HAD REMOVED PRIYA MEHTA FROM THAT ROOM HAD CAPABILITIES AND INTENTIONS THAT THE DIVISION WOULD NEED TO THINK VERY CAREFULLY ABOUT BEFORE IT MOVED.

SHE WATCHED ARJUN.
SHE WAITED.
SHE KEPT THE FILE IN THE DRAWER.

BHARATVERSE

VAYU

THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND

CHAPTER 6: THE BRIDGE

IT WAS A SATURDAY IN MONSOON SEASON. THE KIND OF RAIN MUMBAI DOES THAT VISITORS DESCRIBE AS "HEAVY" AND RESIDENTS CALL "FINE, ACTUALLY, IT'S USUALLY WORSE."

HE WAS ON A SITE VISIT TWO KILOMETRES NORTH WHEN THE FAILURE HAPPENED. HE FELT IT IN THE SAME INSTANT THE CABLE ANCHOR BOLTS GAVE WAY.

A SPECIFIC PATTERN OF PRESSURE CHANGE THAT HIS ENGINEER'S BRAIN TRANSLATED INSTANTLY: FORTY-FIVE SECONDS BEFORE THE SECONDARY CABLES FOLLOW. MAYBE LESS.

HE WAS THERE IN THIRTY-EIGHT SECONDS.

A FORTY-METRE SECTION OF THE WALKWAY HANGING AT THIRTY-EIGHT DEGREES.

FORTY-THRSE PEOPLE ON IT WHEN IT FAILED. TWELVE HAD ALREADY MADE IT TO THE SAFER END. THE OTHER THIRTY-ONE WERE SLIDING.

THE REMAINING CABLE SET — TWO ANCHOR POINTS, ALREADY GROANING — WAS NOT GOING TO HOLD THE SECTION'S WEIGHT FOR MORE THAN NINETY SECONDS.

HE DID NOT HAVE A PLAN. HE HAD PHYSICS.

HE POSITIONED HIMSELF BELOW THE HANGING SECTION AND PUSHED — NOT UP, BUT AT THE PRECISE ANGLE TO COUNTER THE ROTATIONAL FORCE.

A COLUMN OF COMPRESSED AIR. A STRUCTURAL BRACE.

HE COULD FEEL THE LOAD — ACTUALLY FEEL IT, THROUGH THE PRESSURE SENSE. THE SAME WAY A BRIDGE ENGINEER FEELS A STRUCTURE THROUGH THE NUMBERS.

HE ADJUSTED CONTINUOUSLY AS THE PEOPLE ON THE DECK SHIFTED THEIR WEIGHT CRAWLING TOWARD THE FIXED END.

TWENTY-ONE PEOPLE MADE IT TO SAFETY THAT WAY.

THEN THE SECTION LURCHED — A SECONDARY CABLE ANCHOR POINT GOING — AND THREE PEOPLE WHO HAD BEEN ALMOST AT THE SAFE END SLID BACK.

ONE OF THEM WENT OVER THE EDGE.

HE CAUGHT HER.

HE PLACED A CUSHION OF COMPRESSED AIR BENEATH HER AT A DENSITY CALCULATED. IN A FRACTION OF A SECOND, TO DECELERATE HER FALL OVER EIGHT METRES RATHER THAN STOPPING IT INSTANTLY.

SHE HIT THE WATER SURFACE SLOWLY, GENTLY, AND THE AIR POCKET KEPT HER AT THE SURFACE UNTIL THE COAST GUARD BOAT THAT HAD ALREADY BEEN SCRAMBLING REACHED HER IN FOUR MINUTES.

THE REMAINING EIGHT PEOPLE ON THE WALKWAY HE GOT OFF IN THE NEXT SEVENTY SECONDS BY PHYSICALLY FLYING THEM IN PAIRS TO THE FIXED END.

ONE ARM AROUND EACH PERSON, MOVING IN ARCS LOW ENOUGH NOT TO TERRIFY THEM MORE THAN THEY ALREADY WERE.

THEN HE WENT UP, AWAY FROM THE CAMERAS AND THE PHONES AND THE LIGHTS, AND HOVERED IN THE RAIN OVER THE ARABIAN SEA FOR A WHILE AND BREATHED.

HE HAD BEEN SEEN.
HE HAD KNOWN HE WOULD BE.
HE HAD GONE ANYWAY.
HE HAD NOT, IT TURNED OUT, BEEN ABLE TO DO ANYTHING ELSE.

MUMBAI LIVE

NEWS 24

BREAKING NEWS

MYSTERY HERO SAVES DOZENS IN SEA LINK RESCUE

WITNESSES DESCRIBE "MAN IN THE SKY"

ONE WOMAN ON THE WALKWAY HAD LOOKED DIRECTLY AT HIM DURING THE RESCUE.

"HE LOOKED TERRIFIED."

THEN SHE PAUSED, AND ADDED: "BUT HE DIDN'T STOP."

THE CITY HAD SEEN SOMETHING THAT COULD NOT BE EXPLAINED.

AND FOR ARJUN, THE QUESTION WAS NO LONGER WHETHER HE COULD STAY HIDDEN.

BUT WHAT HAPPENS NOW.

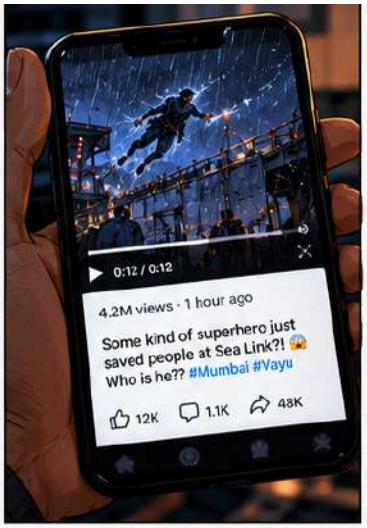
BHARATVERSE

VAYU

THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND

CHAPTER 7:
AFTER

THE VIDEO QUALITY WAS POOR — RAIN, MOTION BLUR, THE PHONE OF A PANICKED PERSON — BUT IT WAS ENOUGH.
A FIGURE, MOVING BETWEEN PEOPLE ON A COLLAPSED WALKWAY WITH VISIBLE DISPLACEMENT OF AIR AROUND HIM.
THE CLIP WAS TWELVE SECONDS LONG AND IT WAS EVERYWHERE WITHIN THE HOUR.



THE INTERNET HAD A NAME FOR HIM WITHIN SIX HOURS: VAYU.
AFTER THE VEDIC GOD OF WIND.
HE DID NOT CHOOSE THIS.
HE WOULD NOT HAVE CHOSEN THIS.
BUT IT ARRIVED AND IT STUCK.



THE GOVERNMENT SAID NOTHING OFFICIAL FOR SEVENTY-TWO HOURS.



A RELIGIOUS DEBATE ABOUT WHETHER VAYU WAS A DIVINE MANIFESTATION OR AN ABOMINATION.

A BLESSING FROM THE GODS.

A DISCOURSE ABOUT WHETHER HIS ACTIONS CONSTITUTED ACCOUNTANT.

AN FOR THE PEOPLE.

UNOFFICIALLY, SHALINI BOSE GOT FOUR CALLS IN ONE NIGHT FROM PEOPLE ABOVE HER IN THE DIVISION'S SHADOW HIERARCHY, ALL OF THEM WANTING TO KNOW THE SAME THING: WAS THIS THEIR GUY?

Yes.

What are you going to do about it?

I'm going to wait.

THE PUBLIC REACTION WAS SOMETHING NO ONE HAD A TEMPLATE FOR.



THERE WAS EUPHORIA — GENUINE, UNCOMPLICATED JOY, THE KIND THAT A CITY UNDER MONSOON STRESS AND POLITICAL FATIGUE GENERATES WHEN SOMETHING EXTRAORDINARY HAPPENS THAT IS PURELY AND UNAMBIGUOUSLY GOOD.

THERE WERE VIDEOS OF THE WOMAN WHO HAD FALLEN BEING MET BY HER CHILDREN AT THE HOSPITAL.

"THE WIND CAUGHT ME."

A POLITICAL ARGUMENT ABOUT WHETHER HE REPRESENTED A NATIONAL SECURITY ASSET OR THREAT.

A NATIONAL ASSET.

A POTENTIAL THREAT.

A DISCOURSE ABOUT WHETHER HIS ACTIONS CONSTITUTED VIGILANTISM.

VIGILANTISM SETS A DANGEROUS PRECEDENT.

AND FROM A SMALL BUT VOCAL CONTINGENT: THE FIRST DEMANDS FOR ACCOUNTABILITY, FOR TRANSPARENCY, FOR ANSWERS ABOUT WHAT EXACTLY HE WAS AND WHO HAD AUTHORIZED HIM TO BE IT.





HE WENT TO WORK ON MONDAY.
HIS COLLEAGUES LOOKED AT HIM SIDEWAYS, WHICH MEANT THEY WERE WONDERING ABOUT THE FIGURE IN THE VIDEO AS A GENERAL CULTURAL CURIOSITY, NOT THAT THEY SUSPECTED HIM.



HE FILED HIS REPORTS.
HE ATE LUNCH ALONE.
HE WAS, AT THIS MOMENT, THE MOST FAMOUS UNKNOWN PERSON IN INDIA.

HIS MOTHER CALLED ON SUNDAY AND DID NOT MENTION VAYU, WHICH MEANT SHE WAS THINKING ABOUT VAYU CONSTANTLY.

How's the rain there? Your father's knee is better now.

Yes, it's better. Mango season should be good this year.

HE DID NOT MENTION IT EITHER.

HE WAS NOT HAPPY.
HE WAS NOT UNHAPPY.

HE WAS IN A STATE THAT FELT LIKE THE MOMENT BETWEEN IDENTIFYING A STRUCTURAL FAULT AND DECIDING WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT — A LUCID, PRECISE WAITING.

HE KNEW SOMETHING WAS COMING.



HE COULD FEEL IT THE WAY HE FELT AIR PRESSURE: NOT WITH CERTAINTY ABOUT THE FORM, BUT WITH CERTAINTY ABOUT THE FORCE.

HE DID NOT HAVE TO WAIT LONG.



BHARATVERSE

VAYU

THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND

CHAPTER 8:

DR. RAO

HE FOUND DR. KIRAN RAO FOUR MONTHS AFTER THE BRIDGE. NOT BECAUSE SHE HAD BEEN HIDING BADLY — SHE HAD BEEN HIDING WELL, IN A LEASED LAB SPACE IN A PUNE INDUSTRIAL ESTATE REGISTERED UNDER A SHELL COMPANY.

HE FOUND HER BECAUSE HE WAS PATIENT AND METHODICAL. HE TRACED THE ENERGY SIGNATURE OF THE EQUIPMENT SHE WAS USING — SPECIFIC ATMOSPHERIC-PRESSURE INSTRUMENTS THAT LEFT A FINGERPRINT IN THE AIR HE HAD LEARNED TO READ — ACROSS THREE CITIES BEFORE THEY STOPPED MOVING.

HE WENT ON A WEDNESDAY NIGHT.

HE TOLD HIMSELF HE WAS GOING TO CONFRONT HER.

SHE WAS NOT SURPRISED TO SEE HIM. SHE TURNED AROUND WITH AN EXPRESSION THAT WAS NOT FEAR AND WAS NOT DEFIANCE — IT WAS SOMETHING CLOSER TO READINESS, THE FACE OF SOMEONE WHO HAS BEEN EXPECTING A RECKONING AND HAS DECIDED TO MEET IT STANDING UP.

You signed over my report.

Yes.

Twelve people died.

Yes.

My sister is gone.

Your sister is not gone.

HE DID NOT MOVE FOR A LONG MOMENT. THE AIR IN THE ROOM DISPLACED VERY SLIGHTLY TOWARD HER — INVOLUNTARY, A WARNING HE HAD NOT CONSCIOUSLY SENT.

SHE NOTICED IT. AND DID NOT STEP BACK.

WHAT YOU ABSORBED IN THAT ROOM WAS NOT A PRODUCT OF MY EXPERIMENT. THE EXPERIMENT WAS A TRIGGER. WHAT IT TRIGGERED WAS SOMETHING I HAD BEEN TRYING TO REACH FOR TEN YEARS — SOMETHING IN THE DECCAN SUBSTRATE, A FORCE THAT PREDATES EVERY HUMAN STRUCTURE IN THIS COUNTRY BY GEOLOGICAL AGES.

I HAVE BEEN STUDYING ANOMALOUS PRESSURE READINGS IN DEEP-EARTH STRATA AT CERTAIN SITES ACROSS INDIA SINCE 2004. THE AHERI FACILITY WAS BUILT OVER ONE OF FIVE CONVERGENCE POINTS BECAUSE I CHOSE IT DELIBERATELY. I WAS TRYING TO ACTIVATE WHAT WAS THERE. I DID NOT KNOW WHAT WOULD HAPPEN IF IT WORKED. I KNOW NOW.

FIVE CONVERGENCE POINTS

- AHERI (Activated)
- RANN OF KUTCH
- HIMALAYAN FOOTHILLS
- EASTERN GHATS
- SOUTHERN TIP

You were trying to weaponize it.

I was trying to understand it. There is a difference. There are people who want to weaponize it — they're the ones who took your sister.

She absorbed something too, in that room. A different force from a different convergence point — I don't fully understand the mechanism yet. She was the only other person in the room in the right physical state, the right kind of open. The people who took her knew this would happen. They were watching the facility. They were faster than I was.

Who took her.

An organization with no public name. They've been ahead of me on this research by at least three years. They have resources I don't. They have at least one other convergence point already under their control.

HE STOOD VERY STILL. HE WAS CALCULATING. HE WAS ALSO TRYING NOT TO LET THE AIR IN THE ROOM GO DANGEROUS.

To find Priya, you need to understand what you are — what she is — what all five of these forces are and what they mean together. I have most of that information. I've spent ten years building it. I need someone who can operate where I can't.

You want me to work with you.

I want to help you find your sister. What you do with that after is your decision.

HE TURNED AWAY FROM HER. HE STOOD AT THE DOOR. HE WAS IN THE RAIN FOR A LONG TIME.

HE THOUGHT ABOUT TWELVE PEOPLE AND ABOUT PRIYA'S FACE AND ABOUT THE DECCAN ROCK AND ABOUT THE WEIGHT OF ORDINARY THINGS AND THE WEIGHT OF EXTRAORDINARY THINGS AND WHETHER THERE WAS A VERSION OF HIS FUTURE THAT WAS STILL THE ROUTINE HE HAD BUILT.

THERE WASN'T. HE HAD KNOWN THAT FOR MONTHS. HE HAD BEEN AVOIDING KNOWING IT.

HE CAME BACK INSIDE.

Show me everything.

BHARATVERSE

VAYU

THE MAN WHO BECAME WIND

CHAPTER 9: VAYU BEGINS

HE QUIT HIS JOB ON A THURSDAY. IT WAS A PERSONAL MATTER.

HE CLEANED OUT HIS DESK, WHICH TOOK ELEVEN MINUTES BECAUSE HE HAD ALWAYS KEPT VERY LITTLE THERE — A DESK THAT LOOKED LIKE IT BELONGED TO SOMEONE PASSING THROUGH.

HE TOLD HIS MANAGER IT WAS A PERSONAL MATTER.

HE CALLED HIS MOTHER ON SUNDAY, NOT AT 10 AM BUT AT 8, WHICH **TOLD HER** IMMEDIATELY THAT SOMETHING HAD CHANGED.

Is this about Priya?

Yes.

Then go.

HE TOLD HER THAT HE WAS GOING TO BE WORKING ON SOMETHING HE COULDN'T EXPLAIN YET, THAT HE WAS SAFE, THAT HE WOULD STAY IN TOUCH.

DR. RAO HAD MAPS. DECADES OF SEISMIC AND PRESSURE DATA OVERLAID WITH ANCIENT SITE SURVEYS AND AN INTUITION THAT HAD LED HER TO A COHERENT THEORY.

FIVE CONVERGENCE POINTS IN THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT, EACH CONTAINING A DORMANT ELEMENTAL FORCE.

VAYU
AIR · ATMOSPHERE
WIND

AGNI
FIRE · PLASMA
THERMAL ENERGY

JAL
WATER · CURRENT
DEEP EARTH FLUID

PRITHVI
EARTH · MASS
SEISMIC FORCE

AKASH
SPACE · CONSCIOUSNESS
THE ETHER

THE AHERI EXPLOSION HAD RELEASED VAYU INTO ARJUN AND — THEY BELIEVED — AKASH INTO — PRIYA. THE OTHER THREE CONVERGENCE POINTS WERE DORMANT.

THE ORGANIZATION THAT HAD TAKEN PRIYA KNEW THEIR LOCATIONS.

"IF THEY ACTIVATE ALL FIVE," DR. RAO SAID, "AND THEY CONTROL THE VESSELS — THE PEOPLE THE FORCES CHOOSE — THEY DON'T HAVE A WEAPONS PROGRAM. THEY HAVE SOMETHING CONSIDERABLY WORSE."

HE BUILT A ROUTINE.

PHYSICAL TRAINING AT 5 AM ON THE MARINE DRIVE.

ATMOSPHERIC WORK FROM MIDNIGHT TO 2, TESTING RANGE AND PRECISION, EXTENDING WHAT HE COULD DO IN CONTROLLED INCREMENTS.

THE REST OF THE TIME: RESEARCH, PLANNING, THE PATIENT, UNGLAMOROUS WORK OF TRYING TO LOCATE A SECRET ORGANIZATION THAT HAD A THREE-YEAR HEAD START.

HE WAS NOT A HERO. HE HAD NOT DECIDED TO BE A HERO. HE HAD DECIDED TO FIND HIS SISTER AND STOP PEOPLE WHO WERE DOING SOMETHING GENUINELY CATASTROPHIC WITH FORCES THAT SHOULD NOT EXIST, AND THOSE THINGS REQUIRED CAPABILITIES HE HAPPENED TO HAVE.

THE HEROISM WAS A SIDE EFFECT.

THEN A BUILDING CAUGHT FIRE IN THANE.

THREE FLOORS COMPROMISED. TWELVE PEOPLE TRAPPED ABOVE THE COLLAPSE POINT.

HE WENT, BECAUSE HE FELT IT AND HE COULD AND SO THE CALCULUS WAS SIMPLE.

A FERRY IN TROUBLE OFF ALIBAG.

HE WENT.

A GAS LINE EXPLOSION IN SION.

HE WENT.

A LANDSLIDE ON THE PUNE HIGHWAY IN A BAD MONSOON WEEK.

HE WENT.

HE WAS FASTER EACH TIME. MORE PRECISE. THE TERROR FADED — NOT ENTIRELY, BUT ENOUGH.

WHAT REPLACED IT WAS NOT COURAGE EXACTLY. IT WAS THE FEELING AN ENGINEER GETS WHEN A STRUCTURE PERFORMS AS DESIGNED UNDER LOAD: A SATISFACTION THAT IS ALSO A RELIEF. THE PROOF THAT THE CALCULATION WAS RIGHT.

THE CITY BEGAN TO LEAVE THINGS.

Thank you, Vayu.

VAYU

A NOTE ON THE MARINE DRIVE RAILING.

A CHILD'S DRAWING — A FIGURE MADE OF WIND, NOT VERY ACCURATE ANATOMICALLY BUT THE INTENTION CLEAR.

FLOWERS AT THE BANDRA-WORLI APPROACH.

HE READ ABOUT THESE THINGS. HE DID NOT GO TO LOOK AT THEM.

HE WAS NOT DOING IT FOR THE CITY. HE WAS DOING IT FOR PRIYA.

THE CITY JUST HAPPENED TO BE IN THE WAY OF EVERYTHING HE WAS, AND SO HE KEPT SAVING IT. OVER AND OVER. AS A KIND OF SIDE EFFECT OF BECOMING HIMSELF.